

# 7. Discussion

## 7.1 Key Findings

The findings reveal a consistent gap between the physical presence of public infrastructure and citizens' experiences of service delivery across the study region. Cash access recorded the highest overall mismatch rate (11.8%), indicating that many respondents continued to experience severe shortages of cash services despite the presence of banking or financial service infrastructure. Health (5.9%), water (5.4%), and electricity/fuel (4.0%) followed with substantially lower mismatch rates.

Considerable variation was also observed across countries. Angola recorded the highest average mismatch rate (12.1%), followed by Lesotho (11.2%), Uganda (10.2%), Eswatini (10.1%), and Zambia (9.9%). In contrast, Mauritius recorded the lowest average mismatch rate (1.2%), followed by Tanzania (1.8%) and Madagascar (4.5%), indicating a closer alignment between observed infrastructure and citizens' reported access to services.

Differences across locations were also evident. Peri-urban and rural communities generally experienced higher mismatch rates than urban areas, particularly for cash access and health services. These findings suggest that infrastructure availability does not necessarily translate into reliable service delivery and that disparities remain across both countries and settlement types.

## 7.2 Limitations

Several limitations should be considered when interpreting the results. First, the study relies on cross-sectional survey data, which limits the ability to establish causal relationships between infrastructure presence and service outcomes. Second, the analysis is based on self-reported shortage experiences, which may be influenced by individual perceptions and reporting differences across countries. Third, the mismatch indicators capture service conditions at a single point in time and may not fully reflect changes in service delivery over longer periods. Despite these limitations, the Afrobarometer data provide valuable insight into the relationship between observed infrastructure and citizens' lived experiences across Southern Africa.

## 7.3 Policy Implications

The results suggest that expanding infrastructure alone may be insufficient to improve public service outcomes. Greater attention should be directed toward improving the reliability and functionality of existing services rather than focusing solely on infrastructure expansion. Cash access deserves particular policy attention because it consistently recorded the highest mismatch rates across countries and location types. Targeted interventions may also be required in countries with the highest overall mismatch rates, particularly Angola, Lesotho, Uganda, Eswatini, and Zambia, as well as in peri-urban and rural communities where service delivery gaps remain more pronounced. Regular monitoring that combines infrastructure assessments with citizen-reported experiences can provide a more comprehensive understanding of public service performance.

## 7.4 Conclusion

This study examined the Public Service Visibility Paradox using Afrobarometer Round 9 data from 16 Southern African countries by comparing the observed presence of public infrastructure with citizens' experiences of severe service shortages. The findings show that visible infrastructure does not always translate into reliable service delivery, with cash access exhibiting the highest mismatch rates, followed by health, water, and electricity/fuel services. Considerable variation was also observed across countries, with Angola, Lesotho, Uganda, Eswatini, and Zambia recording the highest average mismatch rates, while Mauritius and Tanzania demonstrated the lowest levels of mismatch. In addition, peri-urban and rural communities generally experienced greater service-delivery gaps than urban areas. Overall, the study highlights the importance of evaluating not only whether infrastructure exists but also whether it provides consistent and reliable services. These findings suggest that improving the functionality and quality of existing infrastructure, particularly in high-mismatch countries and underserved communities, is essential for strengthening public service delivery across Southern Africa.